

In Focus Dja Faunal Reserve

Dja Faunal Reserve

A natural treasure with diverse social representations

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View of the Baka pygmy village, Dja Faunal Reserve (Cameroon).

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The Dja Reserve is one of Africa's most species-rich rainforests. It includes the habitat of numerous remarkable animal and plant species, many of which are globally threatened.

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The Dja Faunal Reserve is the only protected area in Cameroon with triple status: wildlife reserve, Biosphere Reserve and World Heritage site. These three designations make Dja unique and subject it to the requirements of the Man and Biosphere Programme (MAB) and the World Heritage Convention.

Identified as early as 1950 as the Dja Wildlife and Hunting Reserve by the Cameroonian government, it was recognized by UNESCO in 1981 as a Biosphere Reserve and in 1987 as a World Heritage site. Today, the Dja Faunal Reserve (526,004 ha) is the largest of Cameroon's protected areas and is also part of the Tri-national Dja-Odzala-Minkébé (TRIDOM) landscape between Cameroon, Congo and Gabon in the dense and humid forests of the Congo Basin.

The evolution in its status testifies to the interest the public authorities and international community have shown in this protected area, due to its exceptional riches and the multifaceted benefits expected from its sustainable management.

The Dja: Biosphere Reserve and World Heritage site

For the local and indigenous communities, the Dja Faunal Reserve is 'the forest that God gave them to take from it all they need to live'. Its rich ecosystem and biodiversity provide vital services for people, including food, clean air and water, temperature regulation and carbon storage. The WDN inventory lists 109 species of mammals in 10 orders and 34 families, 360 species of birds and 62 species of fish, as well as a species of bat (*epomops buettikoferi*) identified for the first time on the site. In addition, it has 270 species of trees in 52 families and 187 genera, and a high carbon sequestration and storage capacity of approximately 209.97 t/ha.

This great biodiversity has major potential for ecotourism. In addition to the natural wealth (rocky outcrops, clearings, salt marshes and the Dja River, which surrounds more than 80 per cent of the reserve), there are local Bantu and Baka communities that are the bearers of a millenary culture, with knowledge that benefits conservation.

The UNESCO biosphere reserves are models of good sustainable development practices. Aiming to reconcile humans and nature and to achieve integrated land management, they are divided into three interdependent zones, a classification making it possible, in principle, to satisfy the needs of all of the site's stakeholders. The core zone (in this case, the Reserve) is strictly protected, while the surrounding buffer zone is used for activities compatible with environmentally sustainable practices that can enhance research, training and education. Finally, in the transition zone, economic development activities that respect the human rights and needs of indigenous peoples are allowed.

The Dja Reserve was inscribed on the World Heritage List in 1987. At the time of the property's inscription, several thousand people lived on the periphery of the reserve, where they carried out various economic activities, mainly in agriculture and timber extraction. It is therefore essential to establish a link between the two designations, Biosphere Reserve



At the time of World Heritage listing in 1987, 90% of the area was considered intact and human pressure was low.

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and World Heritage site, to improve their integrated management.

Importance of dual designations to develop an integrated development plan

From the 2000s on, Cameroon, like most countries in the Congo Basin, embarked on economic emergence programmes characterized by the development of transport and energy production infrastructures, the establishment of agro-industries and the development of mines, in addition to the logging already under way. Long before this period, the fall in commodity prices (cocoa and coffee) had already affected the populations living in the Reserve by drastically reducing their main source of income. The threat was so great that at the 36th session of the World Heritage Committee in 2012, consideration was given to inscribing the Dja Faunal Reserve on the List of World Heritage in Danger, subject to action by the State Party.

From 2013 to 2019, between the Committee's 37th and 43rd sessions, the

State Party and its partners worked together to follow up on the committee's various recommendations and to prevent the site's inscription on the Danger List. Specifically, the State Party was asked to review the mining exploration permits; suspend the mining work of GEOVIC until the company carried out an environmental and social impact assessment to meet international standards, before any exploitation of the site began; define, in consultation with the company Sud Hévée Cameroun, the measures to be taken to prevent, reduce and compensate for the negative effects of the rubber tree exploitation project on the Outstanding Universal Value (OUV) of the property; suspend the Mekin Dam construction work until appropriate measures to mitigate the direct and indirect impacts on the property's OUV were submitted to the World Heritage Centre for consideration by IUCN; and finally, create a buffer zone around the property, in which only activities compatible with the conservation of its OUV would be allowed.

In parallel, in order to meet the requirements for Biosphere Reserve

designation, and as part of the updating of the development plan, multiple discussions have taken place to define the zoning of the reserve and its peripheral zones, which is a priority in the implementation of the said plan.

Several contributions – the funds made available by the Central Africa World Heritage Forest Initiative (CAWHFI) for activities implemented since 2016 by the African Wildlife Foundation (AWF) and the Zoological Society of London (ZSL), with funding from the European Union through the Central African Forest Ecosystem Programme (ECOFAC VI) from 2017 onwards; the various field missions, in particular that of the reactive monitoring of the WHC in 2015; and the mission of the CAWHFI project in March 2018, as well as UNESCO's advisory missions and those of the consultants – have been important for supporting the State Party's search for solutions, and for creating platforms for exchange with the various local stakeholders, such as the Dja Forum of actors (see box on p.35).



The Reserve has a population of Baka pygmies who live in a relatively traditional manner and confer a recognized cultural value to the site.

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Dja actors' Forum for consultation between local actors and mobilization of partners

To take into account the contributions of all site stakeholders to meet the World Heritage Committee's requirements, a structured decision-making mechanism at the level of the Reserve has been set up by the different actors (public, private, civil society, local communities and donors) under the leadership of the AWF. The mechanism allows for the careful and organized analysis of natural resource management decisions. It provides decision-makers (government and the Committee) with an overview of how their objectives can be met through technical and practical measures. This has taken form in the field through the creation of a Dja actors' Forum. At the rate of two sessions per year since 2016, six sessions have already brought together the site's actors.

The mechanism facilitated joint elaboration of the Reserve's budgeted work plan by all actors, in order to pool resources, avoid duplication and promote

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complementarity. It enabled them to participate in elaborating the development plan and the strategic environmental and social impact assessment. The various stakeholders were also able to share information on the Mekin hydroelectric dam project and the Sud Hévéa Cameroun company's hevea plantation project. Finally, the mechanism facilitated the inclusion of human rights issues in the development plan, regarding the implementation of conservation activities.

Local communities bring added value to Reserve resources

Local communities need to see the Dja Faunal Reserve as an opportunity and not as a restriction. Creating a local economy

around the site through the development of value chains for non-timber forest products (NTFP) and agroforestry products is an option developed since 2013 by the AWF and the NGO Tropical Forest and Rural Development. It has brought about a positive transformation in community life.

The Dja Faunal Reserve offers a wide range of NTFPs that are known to local communities but remain under-exploited or even sometimes untapped. The valorization of NTFPs by women in the Reserve starts with good techniques for collection in the forest and drying at the village to ensure the quality of the final product. A second transformation produces virgin oils or butters, and a third one the beauty creams and massage balms used by women in the



Dja Faunal Reserve belongs to the forest block considered to be the largest in Africa for the maintenance of biological diversity.

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Almost completely surrounded by the Dja River, which forms a natural boundary, the reserve is especially noted for its biodiversity and a wide variety of primates.

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Reserve, Cameroon and around the world. After using these virgin creams and oils, the ECOFAC VI communications officer remarked that the Reserve is giving women the beauty of nature!

Experts agree that product quality and market demand are key elements to help develop a local economy on the periphery of the Dja Faunal Reserve.

The Dja Faunal Reserve in the face of modernity

Given the private sector's growing interest in the resources on its periphery, the site is clearly undergoing a period of change. The support of the WHC provides assurance that the criteria leading to the inscription of the property on the World Heritage List will be preserved. The State Party and its partners will need to keep the frameworks for exchange and dialogue operational and implement the development plan for the period 2020-2025. The connectivity of migration corridors for large mammals should be a priority, in order to ensure gene exchange. Scaling up the local development model (land-use plan, agroforestry, NTFP development, community mobilization, inclusive finance and community vigilance committee), as implemented in the Dja's northern loop, will help ensure that the large fauna migration corridors continue to function. 🌿

Better care for forest sites in Central Africa

The conservation, sustainable exploitation and management of forest sites in Central Africa, especially in Cameroon, Congo, Gabon and the Central African Republic, have since 2002 benefited from the activities of the Central Africa World Heritage Forest Initiative (CAWHFI). Implemented by the World Heritage Centre, CAWHFI aims to strengthen the management of protected areas while improving their integration within the region's various ecological landscapes. Using the World Heritage Convention as a tool to boost international cooperation in cultural and natural heritage conservation in Central Africa, it has achieved major success, for example the inscription of the Tri-national de la

Sangha (TNS) in July 2012 on the World Heritage List. The TNS property was the first transboundary tripartite nature site to receive this international recognition.

Between 2016 and 2020, funding from the European Union enabled CAWHFI to intensify monitoring in an area of more than 225,000 km² that encompasses three World Heritage sites (Dja Faunal Reserve in Cameroon, Ecosystem and Relict Cultural Landscape of Lopé-Okanda in Gabon and Tri-national de la Sangha in Cameroon, Central African Republic and Congo). The measures included increasing anti-poaching patrols (more than 3,500 patrols and 300,000 km travelled), introducing innovative technologies (SMART, trap cameras, drones

and remote sensing, for example) and training more than 350 eco-guards.

CAWHFI's support has also improved site management by rehabilitating infrastructure, promoting ecotourism, involving and training local communities (more than 3,000 people) and updating/producing wildlife inventories (including elephants, gorillas and chimpanzees). In addition, CAWHFI provided technical support to the Congolese and Gabonese authorities to prepare nomination dossiers for two more forest sites, Odzala-Kokoua and Ivindo National Parks.

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